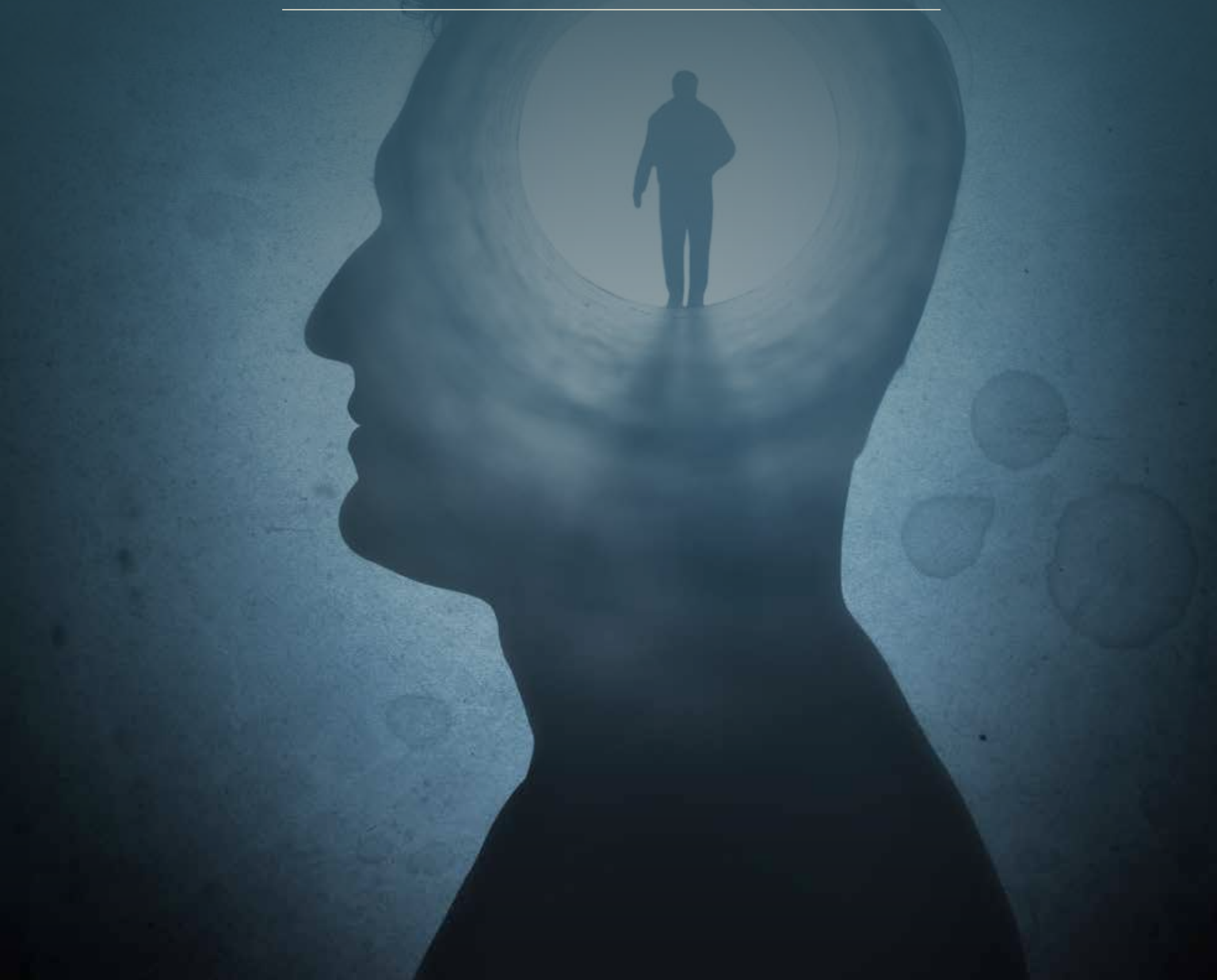
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METAPHOR DIARIES

JOURNEY THROUGH THE ENDLESS POSSIBILITIES OF METAPHOR





Aditya Save

Find Your Laila

> Arjun suffered from thalassophobia.
> Or at least, that is what he told himself.

Thalassophobia, for those who still haven't googled the term, is an irrational fear of deep water, such as the sea or a large and deep swimming pool. In Arjun's case, this fear stopped him from exploring the ocean. He would sit on the beach with his laptop while his friends took a swim in the cool waters on a perfect warm day.

That fear was also responsible for his outburst, when he realized that his friends had tricked him into taking a scuba diving class.

Sounds familiar ?

Are you fretting bec you think that I am plagiarizing someone's story?

Relax. Breathe.

I am describing ZNMD.

I know it. I know that you know it now.

But that isn't the point of this story.

So stay with me for now.

So back to Arjun & his 'unkind' friends. And the scuba diving lesson.
Enter Laila.

Laila (or Katrina Kaif, as you see her in your head now) is a certified scuba diving instructor. But she doesn't do this for a living, not full time anyway. Instead, she uses it as an excuse to travel the world and teach part time at some of the world's best diving sites.

Now, if you can get the Katrina image out of your head, picture Laila.



Laila is awesome at what she does. She is professionally trained. She has helped and guided many through their first scuba experiences. She has met 'enthu cutlets' like Imran and *'scary cats'* like Arjun.

Her craft remains the same. The way she handles them differs.

I won't bother you with the details. But she manages to guide them through their training. She holds Arjun's hand (literally sometimes) and gets him through all aspects of the whole journey. She helps him face his fear, on land and then in the ocean. Laila ensures that he experiences everything- first the fear of stepping into the water, then the discomfort of having to go under it, then the absolute panic of having to hold his breath on the ocean floor.

Arjun emerges out of the water like a greek god. It helps that he looks like Hrithik, but don't hold that against him. He looks like someone who has faced his fears and emerged victorious. When asked the secret, he even manages to share the secret like a quotable quote - "*Aasaan hai. Bus Saans lete raho".*



Arjun is the hero of this story. He is the one, who conquers the dark, deep recesses of his mind. And he is the one who also quotes philosophy.

And yet, none of this would have happened without Laila.



She understood his situation. Perhaps even better than he did.
She had seen others like him (may not have looked as good as Hrithik!).
She had seen that fear in others and she had helped them through it.

Without a coach like Laila, Arjun would not have experienced this transformation. And yet, she wasn't even in the frame, when he gave his gyaan about how to conquer that fear.

I hope you find your fear.

I hope you are able to break through.

I hope you find a coach who can hold your hand through it all.

I hope you find your Laila.



Abdullah Taher

Let Me Be Your Lighthouse!

Introduction

Coaching is arguably one of the most effective ways of human development. To understand the reason we should have a clear understanding of coaching. People sometimes become confused when they see different types of coaches like leadership coaches, executive coaches, relationship coaches, professional coaches, business coaches etc. Despite having different areas of coaching, the core function of a coach remains the same. Like a doctor different coaches focus or gain expertise in different areas.

What is coaching?

The International Coaching Federation (ICF) defines coaching as partnering with clients in a thought-provoking and creative process that inspires them to maximize their personal and professional potential. The process of coaching often unlocks previously untapped sources of imagination, productivity and leadership. According to Sir John Whitmore, widely acknowledged as the father of coaching for performance: *"Coaching is unlocking people's potential to maximize their own performance. It is helping them to learn rather than teaching them."*



What is the role of a coach?

Unlike a trainer or mentor a coach never directly solves the problem of coachee/ client. The coach also does not give any advice to coachee. Rather a coach helps clients explore the solution on their(client) own through a dialogue. The function of a coach is to ask right questions so the client can reflect his/her issue. Hence, asking right questions and listening are two core skills a coach must have. It is said that "the quality of life depends on the quality of questions you ask". Simply put- coaching success depends on asking right questions during the conversation.

My Coaching metaphor

Coaches use different metaphors to explain their coaching process. A metaphor also helps easily understand coaching. Lighthouse is my favorite metaphor for coaching as it resembles the role of a coach. I have explained below the different dimensions of the lighthouse and try to relate it with the functions of a coach.

A lighthouse assists in navigation by signaling safe entries to harbors but also by marking dangerous coastlines and hazardous reefs. A coach assists the client in achieving his/her aspirations/valued living by highlighting possibilities and potential pitfalls. Both lighthouse and coach helps their respective clients navigate towards the safe direction.

A lighthouse does not dictate the direction or destination of the boat and a coach also does not determine which values and goals the client should have. This is one of the core differences between a coach and a mentor. A coach never determines the direction for a coachee. Rather a coach puts the light in the thinking process of the coachee so that he/she can find or determine their direction.

A lighthouse Is a temporary aid on a journey, not a permanent one. Likewise, a coach is a temporary support for the client, with the ultimate goal of achieving the client's independence. A coachee completes his/her journey on own. A coach just helps to spark.

A lighthouse is particularly valuable in case of bad weather circumstances/turbulent sea and a coach is also valuable in case of difficult life circumstances. In most cases, clients come to a coach when they face or go through challenging phases in their life. Coaching becomes so valuable for clients to cope with that difficult part of life's journey.

A lighthouse always operates in service of the journey of the boat and a coach always operates in service of the preferred goals and values of the client. A coach focuses on the set goals of the client, not on the client itself.

A lighthouse helps clarify the current position of the Boat and a coach helps the client increase awareness of his current values, goals, strengths, weaknesses, etc. By thought-provoking questions, a coach can challenge the client which helps gain clarity of self-awareness.

A lighthouse Illuminates the current environment of the boat and a coach sheds (new) light on current circumstances. A coach focuses on the present to help clients pave the way for the future.

I want to be the lighthouse for millions of people to help them reach their utmost potential.



Bhushan Rajani

My Coaching Metaphor: SHADOW

> *Who you are is how you coach*

This statement has struck with me since the time I started my coaching journey. That was day 1 when we were asked to write above statement, and I kept thinking what it really means.

I looked around and analysed what could be the best metaphor for coaching and I came up with **'SHADOW'**. Psychology definition of Shadow – *"Shadow is the self's emotional blind spot - the part the ego does not want to acknowledge - projected as archetypes—or, in a metaphorical sense-image complexes, personified within the collective unconscious."*

To me, a coach is a shadow to a coachee who moves the conversation as a coachee wants just like a shadow moves along with body. It's about meeting your coachee where the coachee is. A coach is a reflection of someone who perhaps is finding a solution but actually not looking at the aspects that have been overlooked or suppressed. Per Robert A. Johnson our shadow is what *"we fail to see or know...the refused and unacceptable characteristics [that] collect in the dark corners of our personality".*

This is how I resonates with this beautiful practice called **'Coaching',** wherein by asking **'questions'** you are invigorating the client to find/identify his/her blind spots, shake core thoughts and prejudice and then then surfaces new fresh thoughts and move along in the journey.

The coach as a shadow is not a harbinger of darkness but a beacon of enlightenment. By navigating through the shadows with the coach, individuals can uncover limiting beliefs, fears, and untapped potential. It's a journey of self-discovery where the coach acts as a mirror, reflecting aspects that might be difficult to acknowledge alone.

Limiting beliefs are shadows that often cast a veil over one's true capabilities. The coach, as a shadow, assists in dispelling these shadows by challenging and reframing these beliefs. Through

probing questions and reflective conversations, the coach brings these limiting beliefs into the light, allowing the individual to confront and dismantle them.

Personal growth often involves stepping into the unknown, confronting uncertainties, and navigating through the shadows of ambiguity. The coach, as a shadow guide, supports individuals in developing the courage and resilience needed to traverse these uncharted territories.

In times of change or transition, individuals may feel overwhelmed by the shadows of uncertainty. The coach provides a steady presence, offering insights and strategies to navigate through these shadows. This collaborative journey fosters adaptability and a willingness to embrace the unknown, leading to personal and professional growth.

Feedback becomes a mirror held up to the individual's actions and behaviours, allowing them to see their impact on others and on their own growth journey. The coach, through insightful feedback, guides the individual in making adjustments and refinements, fostering a continuous cycle of learning and improvement.

In the dance between light and shadow, the coach illuminates the path, making the once-hidden terrain visible and navigable. The shadows cease to be places of fear; instead, they become the canvas upon which individuals paint their stories of resilience, self-discovery, and enduring growth. The coach, as a shadow, is not just a guide but a companion in this illuminating journey of personal transformation.

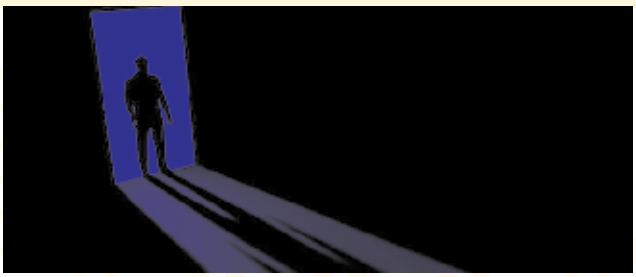
A beautiful poem by Robert Louis Stevenson on ***'Shadow'***

I have a little shadow that goes in and out with me,
And what can be the use of him is more than I can see.
He is very, very like me from the heels up to the head;
And I see him jump before m, when I jump into my bed.

The funniest thing about him is the way he likes to grow—
Not at all like proper children, which is always very slow;
For he sometimes shoots up taller like an India-rubber ball,
And he sometimes gets so little that there's none of him at all.

He hasn't got a notion of how children ought to play,
And can only make a fool of me in every sort of way.
He stays so close beside me, he's a coward you can see;
I'd think shame to stick to nursie as that shadow sticks to me!

One morning, very early, before the sun was up,
I rose and found the shining dew on every buttercup;
But my lazy little shadow, like an arrant sleepy-head,
Had stayed at home behind me and was fast asleep in bed.



Each one of us has a shadow of himself but he cannot understand the use of it. It resembles a human being and behaves like a child. The shadow jumps when he jumps runs when he runs. The shadow follows him wherever he goes !

.....and that's how I envisage to start my new journey !



Deepa Menon

A Light illuminating Peoples Paths Towards Success

Coaching, like light, has the power to illuminate and guide individuals towards their goals and aspirations. Just as light dispels darkness, a good coach provides clarity, support, and motivation to help individuals navigate through life challenges and achieve personal growth. When I was asked to write about my metaphor for coaching the image of a glowing lamp came to my mind. I am reminded of the beautiful vision of a *'Vishu Kani'*- an auspicious image set infront of lord Krishna commemorating Malayali festival of Vishu. In order for the kani to be the first thing we see on a Vishu morning, we would be woken up and made to walk with our eyes closed till we sit in front of the image. The glow coming from the lamp would shine on the creative Kani put together by my mother the previous night and made us feel that we are starting the new year with a vision, clarity and blessings. Its either this childhood memory or the fact that my name itself means a light or lamp, and as I embrace my life's journey to discover purpose I am reminded that perhaps the answer lies in the name.



Just as light illuminates the surroundings, coaches can bring clarity to coachees thoughts and help them get a vision and enable the path forward towards the direction. Through open and honest communication, coaches shed light on blind spots, helping individuals gain a deeper understanding of themselves and their potential.

Light also serves as a guiding force, leading individuals through darkness and uncertainty. Similarly, coaches provide guidance and direction, helping coachees navigate through challenges and obstacles. Coaches also help arrive at a fresh perspective, helping coachees see alternative routes and possibilities.



Light also has the power to inspire and uplift. It evokes a sense of hope, possibility, and motivation. Coaches, too, inspire individuals to reach their full potential by providing encouragement, instilling confidence, and igniting the spark to take action. Like a beacon of light, coaches motivate individuals to persevere, even in the face of adversity.



Light has the ability to transform darkness into brightness. Similarly, coaches facilitate personal transformation and growth. They create a safe and supportive environment for individuals to explore their potential, challenge their limitations, and embrace change.

As light illuminates, guides and transforms the surrounding, coaches play a vital role in helping individuals navigate their personal and professional journeys. Through their expertise, support, and motivation, coaches act as beacons of light, empowering individuals to overcome obstacles, embrace growth, and ultimately achieve their goals.



Janakiram Babu

Caged Mind

IN today's fast paced life and conflicting responsibilities at work and home, there is a huge stress on people. It becomes difficult for most people to balance both work and life mainly due to global competition. This leads to situations where people would limit their thinking and do not take a 360-degree view of situations, resulting in people who are not able to function at their full potential. This further leads to lack in confidence levels and dip in motivation which could be attributed to the caged mindset that people often find themselves in.

> "Change can be hard and traumatic for the mind, but staying with that same state of mind can be dangerous."

If one needs to transform, it is important to embrace change which can show you new paths to grow. One must be determined to break the habits and mindset that has caused them to live a limited life. In order to be mindful and achieve one's full potential coaching can play a key role.

What is coaching?

Coaching is a key element in the overall development of any individual. The discussions or conversations during coaching can help the individual to navigate through the challenges of their careers and foster personal growth by building confidence. Coaching also provides opportunity for people to expand their network and learn from experienced individuals. It provides space and structure to the individual that is necessary for their learning and growth. A coach can also help the individual to gain a better understanding of who they are, identify skills and talents and discover life's meaning and purpose.

This involves complete confidentiality and trust so that the individual can share everything transparently and have an open discussion. During the coaching session, coach helps the individual understand how to approach problems and find solutions. The self-discovery is essential for understanding oneself better and making informed decisions.

Coaching can be of different types such as Leadership coaching, relationship coaching, career coaching, life coaching, skills coaching, communication coaching and so on.

Key aspects in Coaching Session:

- To provide a safe and non-judgmental environment for the individual and encourage honest and open communication, ensure confidentiality, and allow free conversation on both personal and professional front.
- Coaches should work with the individuals to set clear and specific goals, which could be long term or short term.
- Coach should not be focused on results or thrust solutions and only ask the right questions to ensure the individual makes their own action plan.
- In the coaching session, the coach through the questions should be able to show direction, clarity and inspire the individual to look at the future and the action steps required to achieve the objective or goal.
- The coach should focus more on open ended and probing questions and be a very good listener and be fully present during the session. Coaches should not only hear the words spoken but also try and understand the emotions and intent behind them.
- Coaches help the individual to stay accountable for their action plans and commitments. Coaches should ensure that the individuals are focused on their goals through regular checks.
- Coaches also need to encourage reflection to analyse their experiences and make informed decisions.

Why Coaching?

The Purpose of coaching is to make the individual realize their true potential and enhance productivity. Rather than showing them the path with clear instructions, coaching helps them in self-awareness and enables them to make their action plans. Self-realization, reflection, self-correction, and determination make them accountable to achieve their goal.

Coach helps in unlocking the individual's potential for maximizing and enhance performance both at the personal and professional front.

Coaching helps you to come out of the CAGED MINDSET and to become self-aware which can lead to better decision making and personal growth. This also helps them to overcome challenges and reach their full potential to lead more fulfilling lives.



Jahnavi Varampati

Unlocking Human Potential: The Art of Coaching

IN the fast-paced corporate world, where innovation and excellence serve as our guiding stars, we constantly strive to push boundaries, add value, and make a lasting impact. This philosophy has been the North Star of my journey, particularly in my current role at Swym . At Swym, we consistently set our sights on reaching new heights. It's within this dynamic environment that I uncovered the transformative power of coaching, a philosophy that beautifully aligns with our belief in limitless potential and perpetual growth.

My expedition into the world of coaching was initiated by a simple idea that blossomed into a profound passion. I have always been deeply committed to enhancing the human experience, infusing every facet of life with kindness and compassion. For me, coaching emerged as the conduit to amplify my passion and potential, not only for personal growth but also to serve humanity.

I came across a coach whose approach was akin to a gardener tending to a thriving garden. During one of the coaching sessions, he shared a story about a unique bonsai tree he had cultivated over the years. This bonsai had started as a small, ordinary sapling but had grown into a stunning work of art. He explained that the secret to his bonsai's transformation lay in the careful pruning of its branches and leaves.

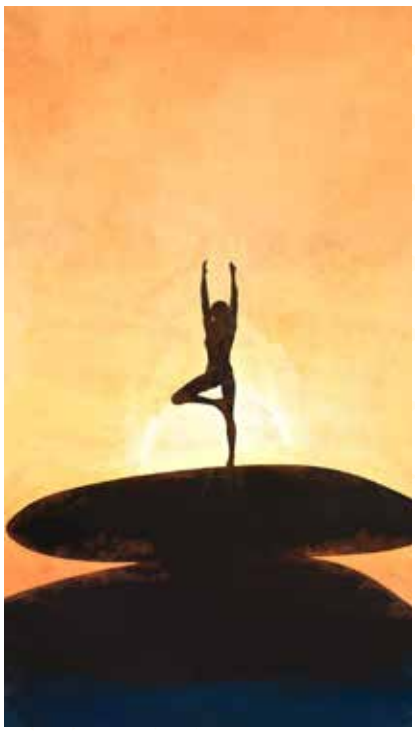
As he pruned away the excess, the tree's innate beauty began to shine. He likened this process to coaching, where the coach's role is to gently prune away the self-doubts, fears, and limitations that hinder personal growth. Much like the bonsai, individuals, when nurtured and guided, have the potential to become something truly remarkable.

This story resonated deeply with me and illuminated a crucial aspect of coaching - the power of selective guidance. It's not about adding more but rather about strategically subtracting to reveal the brilliance within. This approach, whether in the art of coaching or tending to a

bonsai, is a profound lesson in the beauty of simplicity and the potential within each of us.

The experience of hearing this story and witnessing the bonsai's transformation left an indelible mark on my coaching journey. It reinforced the idea that coaching isn't about imposing external visions, but about unearthing the unique potential that already exists within individuals, much like the bonsai tree's intrinsic beauty.

Coaching, I realized, is not merely a profession or a practice. It's an art form. It's the art of being a sculptor of human potential.



To me, Coach is just like a sculptor who takes a raw block of stone and, with skill and precision, carves it into a magnificent work of art, a coach, too, works with individuals. The goal is to chisel away the self-doubt, limitations, and obstacles that often obscure the hidden brilliance within. Through guidance, support, and a deep understanding of each individual's unique qualities, a coach helps shape and refine their talents, ambitions, and self-awareness. The ultimate aim? To help them become the best version of themselves.

What sets coaching apart from other forms of guidance is the profound depth it reaches. A coach does not superimpose their own vision; instead, they unearth and magnify the innate beauty and potential residing within the individual. It's a partnership where the coach acts as the guide and the coachee, the masterpiece in the making.

Coaching, to me, embodies godly wisdom, and a natural form. It carries the wisdom of the divine, guiding individuals toward their highest selves. And, like the natural world, it's a force of growth, organically nurturing the latent abilities within. It's a journey where each individual's unique potential is sculpted into a work of art.

I fervently believe that coaching serves as a transformative force for both individuals and organizations, playing an indispensable role in unlocking human potential.

I am delighted to commence this journey into the world of coaching, a voyage promising to reveal the sculptor within you, whether you're a coach or someone seeking to unveil your hidden brilliance. Thank you Swym for supporting me in pursuing my passion, and thanks to Ramesh Balan , my peer in this journey. Thanks to Gaurav Arora, MCC (ICF) & Preeti Verma, PCC (ICF) for taking me through this wonderful journey with your guidance and expertise. Thanks to my accountability partners Dr Priya Sharma and Nirupama.

Lastly, I must express my heartfelt gratitude to all my professional mentors who have been the guiding stars at every step of my professional journey. Their mentorship and guidance have been invaluable, and I owe a great debt of gratitude to them for shaping me into the person I am today.



K Narender Reddy

Mother Nature

What is my Metaphor of Coaching?



Mother nature enamoured me right from childhood. After an eventful week, I strolled alongside the beaches of Thailand. The beauty of nature gave the perfect backdrop for a peaceful contemplation.

In the vast expanse of my professional journey as the CEO of a natural products company, I find myself drawn to a metaphor that beautifully encapsulates the essence of coaching - the rhythm of nature. As I reflect on the transformative power of coaching, I am reminded of the intricate dance orchestrated by Mother Nature herself.

Much like the gentle touch of the seasons, coaching unfolds with a purposeful cadence. Just as nature provides the ideal conditions for a seed to sprout and blossom into a towering tree, coaching nurtures the latent potential within individuals, creating an environment for personal and professional growth. In the same way that the sun's rays warm the earth and stimulate life, a coach illuminates the path forward, infusing clarity and vision into self-discovery.

In the tapestry of coaching, the parallels with the intricate ecosystems of our natural world become vivid. Like the gardener tending to a vibrant garden, the coach carefully tends to each coachee's unique qualities and aspirations. It is not about imposing a rigid structure but instead creating a fertile ground where individuals can root themselves, finding stability and nourishment to flourish.



As Mother Nature adapts to the changing seasons, a skilled coach recognizes the evolving needs of their coachee. The coaching relationship mirrors the symbiotic balance found in nature, where mutual respect and understanding lead to profound transformations. Coaching guides individuals along a meandering course of self-discovery, shaping and refining their potential like the river that Molds the landscape over time.

As I envision myself evolving in the art of coaching, I see a reflection of my role as a steward of growth. Much like my role in steering a natural products company towards great heights, my coaching journey is anchored in the belief that unlocking the potential of individuals is not only a professional duty but a profound responsibility. Just as a tree extends its branches to provide shade and sustenance, coaching becomes a catalyst for individuals to reach new heights, contributing to the greater ecosystem of success and fulfilment.

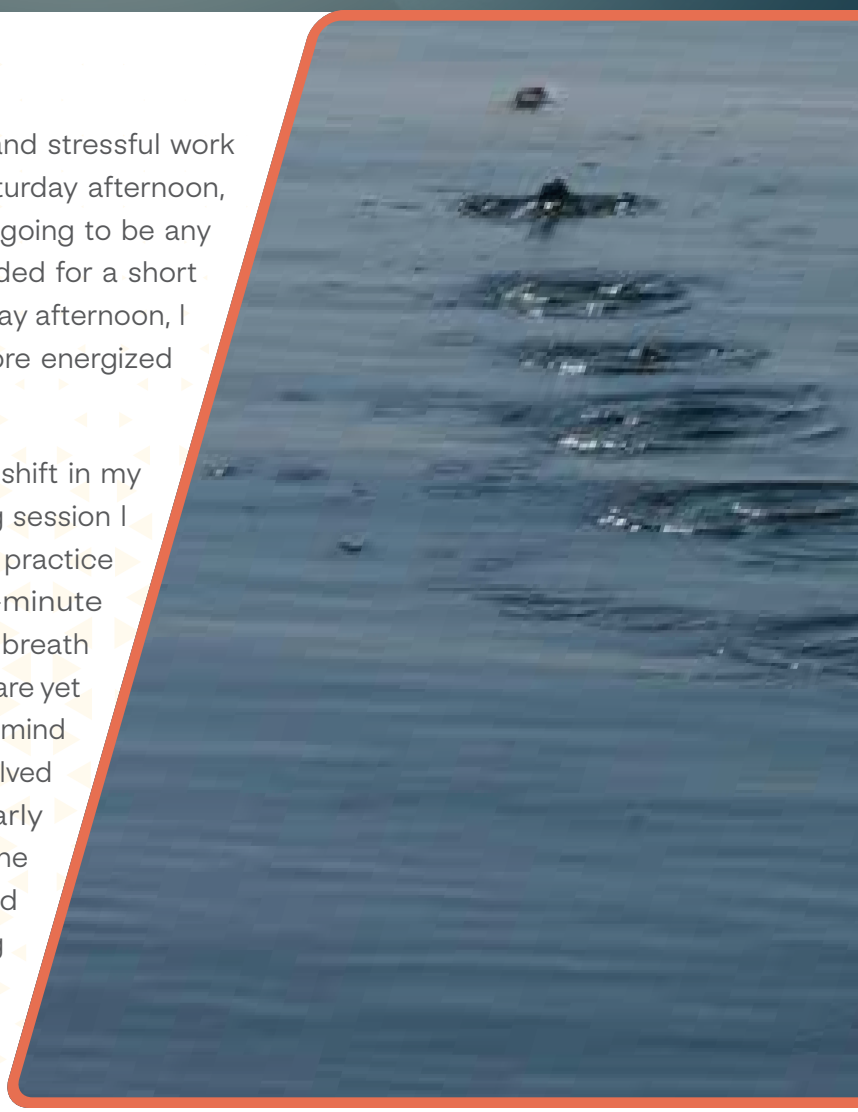
In embracing the metaphor of coaching as the rhythm of nature, I commit to being a beacon of guidance, fostering an environment where the seeds of potential can sprout, grow, and ultimately flourish. Just as Mother Nature orchestrates the symphony of life, coaching becomes the conduit through which individuals and organizations can scale the most incredible heights of their capabilities when practiced with wisdom and compassion.





KEDAR JOSHI

Shing Moon Lake



IT had been a brutally exhausting and stressful work week that stretched well into Saturday afternoon, and I knew the next week wasn't going to be any easier. Despite that overhang, as we headed for a short family picnic to Shing Moon Lake on Sunday afternoon, I felt both relaxed and if anything, even more energized and ready to take on the upcoming week.

One of the key catalysts for this seismic shift in my mood and energy levels was the coaching session I had on Sunday morning. As was the usual practice with my coach, we started with a ten-minute mindfulness exercise by focusing on our breath and tried to (though I struggled) to stay aware yet detached from the barrage of thoughts my mind kept processing. The rest of the session involved a deeper dive into one of the particularly challenging situations I was dealing with. The session lasted over an hour and involved peeling back one layer at a time, exploring many different dimensions of the situation, and working out where I wanted to be as well as my plan to get there.

Back at the Shing Moon Lake, as my daughter and I engaged in a fun competition of who could skip the pebble for a maximum number of jumps over the still water surface, my morning coaching session almost seemed to come alive. I could relate to the soothing and supportive impact the coaching session that morning had on me. The lake's surface was calm and still, almost as pure and sincere as my coach. Each time I threw a pebble (think of it as an idea or a challenge I was facing), the lake water gently held it afloat and propelled it forward into multiple skips over the water. As he asked me numerous questions, he brought the curiosity of a child, yet the detachment of a monk, to help me dig into my deeper self for solutions, and come up with a plan I owned. At times, he pushed back and asked some tough questions, not dissimilar to the gentle resistance offered by the lake water; while at other times, he supported, encouraged, shared a perspective, helped me clarify myself, and surely, never missed an opportunity to celebrate the exploratory journey we were on.



How far a pebble goes, whether it does the usual 4-5 skips or a superlative 10-12 or achieves a new Guinness record at 89 skips, is a function of many things - how good the pebble is, how fast it was thrown, what angle it was thrown at - among many other factors. That said, it was certain that the calm stillness of the lake water was an equally critical catalyst in determining the outcome. And the best part is – as the pebble bounces off the calm still lake water, not only does it gain momentum, but it also reverberates, and creates waves and energy on the water surface. Can't think of many other relationships that are so pure and mutually rewarding!

My doubt regarding 'what might happen if the water was not calm and still' was answered quite shortly as we headed upstream and tried throwing similar pebbles into moving water – only to see our pebbles face turbulence and sink. I suppose, if a coach is consumed with him/herself and can't stay clear, sincere, and whole-hearted in that conversation, the quality of the coaching conversation and the likely outcome are bound to suffer.

As we drove back home that evening, I felt much better reconciled, and energized. But in that moment, I also made a resolute commitment to myself that as I grow to become a good coach, I will always endeavor to bring the same calm stillness of the lake water surface to help my coachees get their ideas the farthest!



Manjunath PRABHAKAR

Being a Compass

IT has been a wonderful journey for me in the last 2 decades where I started early as an entrepreneur, achieved many milestones and in that process started realizing that one of my key strengths is the way I maintain my relationship with people that kept me moving to greater heights. My dad, my idol always taught me in business that ***" Never do business for today, but always do business for tomorrow".*** He was a man of Goodwill, honesty, respectful, humble and responsible. I learnt these values and many more from him which helped me be a better human and build great relationships with people. Over time, I was noticing to have flair for people which then led me to start observing and understanding human behavior and going deeper into it. These thoughts then led me to pursue my formal higher education in Human Resources and that in turn gave me an opportunity to enter the corporate world where I was blessed with many roles being around people till date.

One of my biggest learnings, something that pushes me forward in life till date is ***"trying to understand myself".*** In this process, I had an opportunity to meet many great human beings, friends, professionals, leaders who have guided me, inspired me, helped me navigate in the right direction and have created many wonderful experiences in my life for which i am grateful to every one of them!



With continuous Learning comes growth and I started reaching a milestone over time where many approached me for advice and suggestions, eventually ended up mentoring many professionals around me. I was able to eventually taste success in my mentee's eyes which gave me immense contentment and happiness which became my driving factor.

Now what next? I asked myself! I decided to go deeper into this.

I continued my mentoring journey and supported many, but there was one thing which always kept me in doubt. Am I doing it the right way? What is mentoring? What is coaching? What is the difference? Am sure there is a method to this madness which I became eager to find out.

Thanks to Srinivas GPM,Surapani , Tina Kao Mylon , Morgan Becker, then came a time where I had an opportunity to be coached by a professional certified coach Rachel Cojer to break my own barriers. This coaching intervention for me was an eye opener that gave me a huge amount of clarity and I started seeing things very differently which helped me break my own barriers.

And recently with the guidance of my coach and sponsorship of Srinivas GPM,Surapani & Siva Emani, I have recently entered my journey into the formal world of coaching with Erickson Coaching International - India (An International Coaching Federation Accredited Coach Training Institute) under the guidance of Gaurav Arora, MCC (ICF) for which am grateful to all of them.

As part of my coaching journey, hereby sharing my metaphor of coaching- *"Being a Compass to help navigate others to unleash their unseen strength and embrace the unknown"*

What does this mean to me?

Life, a vast and uncertain ocean, throws waves our way, sometimes gentle currents, sometimes crashing storms. **My metaphor for coaching is a Compass**, a trusted instrument guiding through uncharted waters. It doesn't control the winds, but helps find our bearings, adjust our sails, and navigate towards our personal / professional horizon. **As a coach** I would like to act as the needle, helping people calibrate their internal compass. Challenge assumptions, ask introspective questions, and guide in rediscovering our core values and strength. Through an open dialogue and problem-solving, I would like to help others chart a new course, avoiding shipwreck and staying on track with their desired destination.

Let me help set your sails, calibrate your compass, and embark on the incredible voyage of life with a skilled coach by your side. Remember, with every twist and turn, your journey is rich with purpose, and every destination promises new beginnings.





Niraj Mahajan

The Catalyst

When we were asked to come with our coaching metaphor I was sure that it would not be easy to find one and relate to, and I was right.

Being a finance professional and with a hectic work schedule, it has taken a long time for me to come up with my coaching metaphor, which I am able to relate to as I embark on my coaching journey. The mind kept coming up with different things to relate to but I one thing which I was clear in my head was the role that me as a coach needs to play, hence the best I could relate to was being a Catalyst.

The Catalyst – agent of change, is my coaching metaphor

In a chemical context, a catalyst is a substance that increases the rate of a chemical reaction without undergoing any permanent change itself.

Metaphorically, a catalyst refers to someone that brings or accelerates change, growth, or development.

> Coaching is a process of facilitating a positive change and a progressive shift from where the person is to where he or she would like to be.

A catalyst plays the same role and facilitates that change to happen. In the context of coaching, a coach can be referred to as a catalyst. A coach acts as a guiding force, facilitating positive changes and growth in the individual without imposing their own agenda. The coach supports the coachee in reaching their goals, providing insights, encouragement, and a framework for personal and professional development.



Here is how I relate to *"The Catalyst"* as a coaching metaphor:



Initiating Change:

Like a catalyst, a coach initiates positive changes in a person's life. Coaching prompts individuals to reflect, set goals, and take actionable steps toward their aspirations.

Accelerating Growth:

A catalyst speeds up a reaction, and a coach accelerates personal and professional growth. Through guidance, support, and strategic interventions, a coach helps individuals progress more rapidly toward their objectives.

Remaining Unchanged:

Similar to how a catalyst remains unchanged after a reaction, a coach is there to support without imposing their own agenda. The focus is on the coachee's journey, and the coach provides a stable and consistent presence, adapting their approach to suit the coachee's needs.

Transformation:

A coach transforms perspectives and behaviors. The coaching relationship acts as a catalyst for personal development, helping individuals to break through limiting beliefs and overcome challenges.

Creating Synergy:

Like a catalyst, a coach collaborates with the coachee, creating a strong relationship where both parties contribute to the process of growth and discovery.

Generating Energy:

Coaching brings positive energy and motivation.

Bring the path for Clarity:

A coach helps individuals gain clarity in their goals and decision-making. Through good quality and nudging questions a coach aids in providing a clear direction for the coachee.



According to me *"The Catalyst"* is a powerful coaching metaphor that symbolizes the transformative and initiating force that coaching can have on an individual's life.

Neha Rai

Life is A Journey!

A person who never believed in the concept of coaching is here aspiring whole heartedly to be a coach in near future. For me embarking on this journey was a mix of future calling and inner voice.

I went into the first session with my normal, logical thinking patterns, and came out with a completely different awareness of life, the universe and myself.

For me the journey of a coach, is the journey of a human being.'

After having been into this journey for a month I get a feeling that coaching is about getting to the being of a person – knowing who they are, who they need to become, how they need to change to realize the shift they want to make. It is a process of facilitating a positive and progressive shift from where a person is to where he/she would like to be by creating self-awareness which would in turn create self-responsibility. It is an intuitive process of connecting heart to heart.

When I was asked to pick up a metaphor for coaching a simple statement crossed my mind - LIFE IS A JOURNEY! As a coach, I can use the metaphor of a journey to help a coachee understand the process of achieving their goals. As a coach, I can draw an analogy that just as a journey requires planning, preparation, and perseverance, so does achieving one's goals.

Life is often linked to a journey, and this metaphor can be used to help coachee reflect on where they are, where they want to go, and the steps they need to take to get there. The idea of a journey can convey growth, progress, and the notion that the path might have ups and downs.



Coaching has led me to be more #self-aware and #reflect on areas that I need to work upon before I help others, clear my inner landscape first because ultimately 'Who you are is how you coach'. I truly experienced that reflection comes from a place of self-acceptance and how imperative it is to let go of the beliefs that no longer support you. Thus, emerges the beautiful & creative process which inspires people to maximize their potential by creating self-awareness that enables self-responsibility.

The more I think about it, the more convinced I am that Coaching is a life skill, which helps us deal with situations and dilemmas more effectively and gracefully. Some thoughts that I have garnered from my understanding so far is:

1. Watch your thoughts from a distance

As human beings, we cannot control our thinking minds. It's natural that emotions and thoughts will come and go as ocean waves, but what we can control is how we choose to engage with them. And if viewed from a distance, we get less consumed by these thoughts and get more rationale in our decision making.

Two concepts that stayed with me in implementing the above are:

A - Anchoring my attention to my breath

B - Having gratitude for my thoughts and the patterns which emerged out of it

2. Growth & Contribution = highest form of consciousness

The Coach focuses on helping another person learn in ways that let him or her keep growing & expanding their thoughts. It is based on asking rather than telling, on provoking thought rather than giving directions and on holding a person accountable for his or her goals. Because ultimately people have resources within themselves, which means that all solutions reside internally all you need to do is dig deeper and deeper, one conversation at a time.

3. It's an experience and not a concept that will shift your perspective

Coaching is all about leading the person to be more forward looking, helping him/her visualize their journey and create experiences stemming from their values & capabilities. Through experiences we narrate our stories, shape our personalities and build our perception of life – one of the unique aspects of human beings is that they can design their own lives however only a few people realize and practice it.

One of the most exciting things about coaching is the buzz you get when you push out of your comfort zone, come up with a plan and put it into action! Life takes on a whole new meaning as you re-create your life the way you want it."

– Emma-Louise Elsey



Pradeep Warrier

Sabarimala Temple

Last year during Dashara vacation I with my elder son visited Shabarimala, a pilgrimage site, in Kerala devoted to lord Ayyappa. Typically the season is from mid-November to Dec' end & Sankranti when the temple is open on all days. In the remaining part of the year, temple opens only for 5 days in a month.

I preferred off season to avoid seasonal rush. Like any such journey, it involved commilng to visit the temple & back to place where we start the journey. We reached at mid night at Pamba & from there trekked till temple. We reached the temple early morning, had our darshanam & returned.

There are many things that we are supposed to follow before Sabarimala visit & other religious/ spiritual aspect which I'll not get into here. But few points that remained with me & in-hindsight relating to some aspects in coaching I feel.

At the main temple facade, the words that are scripted are – *'tatvamasi'*- meaning – *'thou are that'*, or *'the one you are searching for you is you'.* It has a deep spiritual message of selfdiscovery & awareness.

In coaching sessions that I attend there is an aspect of discovering self.

The discovery process that starts with the coachee commilng to the journey. Most of the time it is about seeking answers. It takes significant effort & mental preparedness to come forward to come for such session. May be more than commilng to visit the temple.

Just before the session mind sometime gets confusing, blacks out, loses strength for reasons buried deep within us. Uncovering these need coachee's presence & full involvement in the process.

During the trek part of Sabarimala journey, a clouded/de focused my mind took the journey through forest climbing up the mountain in night chanting only the name lord Ayyappa, not aware of surroundings or caring much about other people on the way, not able to realize the natural beauty or inherent danger of the place, deeply concerned only about myself to reach sooner at the top. And sometime thinking about things that didn't go well in life.

And then at the top we are being made to be aware that we have what is needed, through the message on the temple façade, to address all our concerns.

And then on way down returning we see how many steps we were able to climb up, how high we came, how strong were we & how brave were we through the dense forest full of large trees & wild animals. Among pilgrims of all kinds (able, disabled, young, old) climbing we find ourselves to be blessed ones. River water looks clean with fishes that we want to try to catch. Food tastes tasty. The world looks different.

In night when our thoughts were closed chanting only the lord's name during the trek, most of us didn't even try observing the stars in the sky. During return, we find no one is in hurry, our eyes are open, we are aware of nature, our thoughts are with all people climbing up, the same world wonders us & appears full of possibility. Realization of what we did & could do make us positive about life ahead. Makes us confident about having more treks.

In the coaching session a coach helps the coachee peel layers of doubts themselves one by one to get the clarity, helps develop a vision that is wonderful & worth living for.

During this process the coach too goes through transformation. Each question that (s)he asks, deep down he reflects on the same too. Like return from each Sabarimala journey, a_er each session the world looks full of possibility. A_er each session he gets amazed by the inherent strength & potential that each of us has. The feeling that the very nature of life is to progress positively.

While I believe in God, I don't know how real the God is or in which all ways God influences our life. I feel the 'Shabarimala' trek is about self-realization, belief & possibilities. Similarly, the coach helps his coachee realize what one is capable of & can achieve during a coaching session that can appear like this trek.





Pallavi Poddar

Unleashing Your Inner Butterfly

> Just when the caterpillar thought the world was over, it became a butterfly.
>
> *- Anonymous*

Just like a caterpillar have you ever imagined feeling trapped in a monotonous routine, lacking fulfillment, struggling to figure out any direction in life. That's precisely how one I also felt not too long ago, it felt like things are crushing for me and the life is becoming less meaningful. Little did I know that within, just like a caterpillar, there was an untapped potential for transformation into something beautiful and extraordinary. This is where coaching stepped in, like a guiding light showing me the way and illuminating a path forward.





1. **The Journey Within -** From Caterpillar to Cocoon: At the start of any coaching journey, one will found resembling a caterpillar, inching along without purpose or direction. A lot of time trapped in own self-doubt and insecurities. But just like a caterpillar who is yearning for a new beginning unaware of possibilities, coaching can help in see the possibilities that existed within the potential to soar above any limitations. What matters most is Self awareness & Self acceptance of the situation, awareness creates choices , awareness creates possibilities.

2. **Unfolding Butterfly Wings -** Just like the little wings start coming out with so much of struggle, every coaching session offered a transformative opportunity for exploration and growth. The coach creates a safe and non-judgmental space to explore thoughts, fears, and dreams. Their insightful questions and active listening helps peel back the layers, discovering true desires and passions and get the wings to fly high. *"Listen to other person as if you are listening to universe, nature or God".*

3. **Breaking Free -** The Moment of Breakthrough: Like a butterfly emerging from its cocoon, there comes a breakthrough moment in the coaching journey. A moment of clarity, where one finally shed the self-imposed limitations that had held back for so long. Here comes fresh perspective and unleashed true potential.

In life, we all have the potential to become butterflies - to break free from our cocoons and discover our true purpose. Coaching serves as the catalyst for this transformation, guiding us through the journey of self-discovery and personal growth. So, if you ever find yourself feeling stuck or unsure of your path, remember that within you lies the power to spread your wings and embrace your inner butterfly.



Shaifaly Sangal

Walking Stick



When the need arises, coaching can be an excellent resource to support personal or professional development. coaching might be sought for a period until a specific goal is achieved or a skill is developed. Coaching adapts to various needs and stages in life, offering personalized support and guidance where and when it's most beneficial. Its flexibility and tailored approach make it a valuable resource for individuals striving for improvement or facing specific challenges.

For individuals who struggle with staying accountable to their goals or commitments, coaching offers accountability structures and encouragement to stay on track.

For me coaching is like a **walking stick**. Both walking stick and coaching serve as aids that people often turn to when there's a specific need or requirement - be it personal, professional, or even in sports.

That's an interesting comparison I believe! Just like a walking stick can be helpful when someone needs extra support while walking, coaching can be beneficial when someone feels the need for guidance, growth, or improvement in a specific area of their life.



Coaching isn't always a constant necessity for everyone, but it can be incredibly valuable when someone wants to achieve a goal, overcome obstacles, or enhance their skills. A walking stick aids physical support, while coaching offers guidance, motivation, and strategies to navigate challenges or achieve objectives.

It's like having a tool in your toolkit that you use when it serves a purpose or helps you move forward.

It's true that these aids are utilized when necessary, serving as valuable tools precisely when needed. Just as one may put aside a walking stick once they regain strength, individuals might pause coaching sessions once they've achieved their intended goals or developed the necessary skills.



Shwetha Kalappa

Igniting the spark within, How Coaching Brings in Deeper Awareness

Growing up, summer vacations were almost always in my grandparents' home in Mercara, a quaint hill station in the district of Coorg, Karnataka. My grandparents' house was over 100 years old with an old kitchen where food would be cooked over firewood. Of course, we had a modern kitchen in the 90s but I was fascinated about the entire process of cooking food over firewood. Coal or firewood would be lit but for the fire to be ignited my Grand mom would use a cylindrical hollow iron bar called the *"Kholope"* in the Coorg language. I am sure this was the case across different Indian hill stations just the name or reference may be different. She would blow into it gentle, steady and with pauses at the right intervals. Slowly and slowly the flames would be seen and in sometime we had a good fire lit for the vessel to be placed over it.





So, when I was asked to pick a metaphor for coaching, I was reminded of the cylindrical hollow iron bar. Every individual has a spark within waiting to be ignited. The hollow iron bar is what helps in the process of building self-awareness for the coachee. This self-awareness is a long process and it takes a while as the coachee is nudged into thinking and questioning their assumptions and perceptions of what has been their conditioning over years and years. It does not get ignited with one harsh blow but requires a gentle, steady and consistent nudge to get the thinking process going. This of course requires a lot of patience and intentional listening from the coach without any judgement and without a frame of reference that colours the coachee' s thinking process. Just the right amount of probing and questioning to get them to start thinking and unlearning. The result is of course magical as the coach sees the fire within burning and the coachee gets clarity and is able to get their inner spark ignited. Coaching is a process of discovery for both the coach and the coachee where the coach comes in to the conversation after 'emptying' themselves, with a clear mind and eventually helps the coachee in the process of self-awareness and discovery of the answers to their questions.

It is said that the journey is as exciting as the destination, all we need is to embrace it with awareness. Embracing this path of self-awareness as I breathe gentle, steady and consistent to ignite the inner spark within.



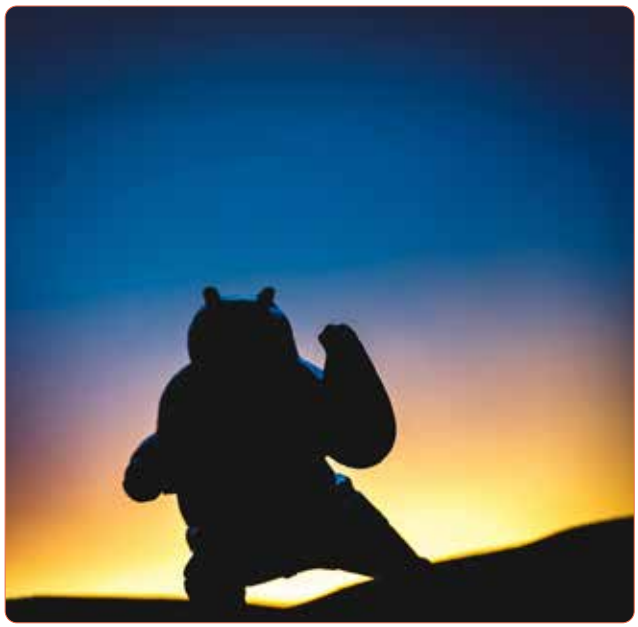
Sandeep Jainapur

Embracing Success Through 'Caching Perspective': A Transformative Journey in Coaching

IN my cinematic experience with Kung Fu Panda, I find the concept of "caching perspective" beautifully portrayed through the journey of the protagonist, Po, the panda. Po, initially perceived as an unlikely and unconventional hero, comes to realize that his unique perspective and background hold intrinsic value.

As I witness Po's training alongside skilled warriors, his distinctive experiences and unorthodox approach to kung fu bring a fresh and innovative perspective to the ancient art. The idea of "caching perspective" becomes evident as Po's unconventional thinking and diverse skills contribute significantly to the overall success of the group.

This concept encourages me to recognize the value of my background and experiences. It suggests that by embracing diverse perspectives, I can enrich my understanding and approach to challenges, just as Po's unique skills ultimately become an essential asset in the world of kung fu.



Certainly, coaching is a dynamic and multifaceted process designed to facilitate my personal and professional growth. Here are some key aspects and principles associated with coaching:

Objective-oriented:

Coaching is goal-oriented. It involves helping me identify and work towards specific objectives, whether they are personal development goals, career aspirations, or skill enhancement.

Supportive Relationship:

A coaching relationship is built on trust, empathy, and open communication. My coach provides a safe and supportive space for me to explore my thoughts, feelings, and aspirations.

Active Listening:

My coach employs active listening skills to fully understand and appreciate my perspective. This involves not only hearing my words but also understanding the emotions and nuances behind them.

Questioning Techniques:

My coach uses a variety of questioning techniques to encourage my self-reflection and exploration. Powerful questions prompt me to think deeply, challenge assumptions, and gain insights into my behavior and goals.

Feedback and Feedforward:

Constructive feedback is a crucial component of coaching. My coach provides feedback on my strengths and areas for improvement, focusing on specific behaviors. Additionally, a forward-looking approach, known as feedforward, emphasizes future development rather than dwelling on past mistakes.

Goal Setting:

My coach assists me in setting SMART goals (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound). Clear and realistic goals provide direction and motivation for my coaching journey.

Skill Development:

Coaching often involves the identification and development of specific skills. This could range from leadership skills and communication abilities to time management and emotional intelligence.

Accountability:

My coach helps me stay accountable for my actions and commitments. Regular check-ins and progress assessments ensure that I am actively working towards my goals.

Transformational Change:

Coaching is not just about achieving immediate objectives but also about fostering long-term transformation. It seeks to create lasting positive changes in my behaviors, attitudes, and perspectives.

Different Coaching Models:

Various coaching models provide a structured framework for coaching sessions. Understanding different models allows me to adapt the approach to solving problems.

Coaching is a flexible and adaptive process that can be applied in various contexts, including executive coaching, life coaching, career coaching, and more. It is a collaborative journey that empowers me to unlock my potential and achieve my aspirations.



Siddharth Taneja

Metaphor :

Has anyone heard the speech by Al Pacino in *"Any Given Sunday"*?

I took the liberty of taking some notes from the speech to explain what coaching means to me.

Journey from hell to the light

Extract from Movie : We're in hell right now, gentlemen, believe me. And, we can stay here -- get knocked out -- or we can fight our way back into the light. We can climb outta hell one inch at a time.

My narrative for coaching : The coachee is in trouble right now. And he/ she can stay there – get knocked out – or can fight their way back into the light. We as a coach can help them to help them with that fight *"One inch at a time".*

The solution is right there

Extract from Movie : The inches we need are everywhere around us. They're in every break of the game, every minute, every second.



My narrative for coaching : in most coaching conversation which I have had till date, I have experienced that the solution lies within. A self exploration journey of the coachee can help him/ her with the solution that is best suited for them. Hence the inches we need are all around us, they just need to dig deeper and solve for it, our goal as a coach is to help them dig deeper.

You are accountable

Extract from Movie : Now, I can't do it for you/ nor can I make you do it. You got to look at the guy next to you. Look into his eyes! Now I think you're gonna see a guy who will go that inch with you.

My narrative for coaching : The coach wont do it for you, you've got to look at the resources available to you within or outside to do what you aspire to do. In a way the coachee will identify the "Guy=resource within or outside" to gain that inch.



Willingness to change/ learn/ challenge their mindset

Extract from Movie : I'll tell you this: In any fight, it's the guy who's willing to die who's gonna win that inch.

My narrative for coaching experience : The coachee has come up to a coach for help, in a way he/ she has stepped into the arena and is willing to be vulnerable(willing to fight).

It takes a lot of courage to come up and say I need help with xyz situation and the coachee has entered the conversation with that courage... RESPECT THAT and do your best as a coach given that the coachee is willing to change/ to learn/ challenge their mindset to win that inch.

Extract from Movie : Inch by inch, play by play, 'til we're finished. That's football guys.

My narrative for coaching : Helping the coachee Inch by inch : one step at a time.
Play by Play : one session at a time.

THAT's COACHING CUYs .....



Thank You!

Everything has seasons, and we have to be able to recognize when something's time has passed and be able to move into the next season. Everything that is alive requires pruning as well, which is a great metaphor for endings.

- Henry Cloud

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